

❖ STUDY BEES ❖

POEM – MOTHER NATURE

by
Emily Dickinson

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About the Poem

"Mother Nature" (also published under its first line, "Nature, the gentlest mother") is a poem by Emily Dickinson, included in *The Poems of Emily Dickinson: Series Two* (1896). Written in six quatrains, it presents Nature entirely as a gentle, patient mother figure who tenderly cares for, disciplines, and finally lulls to sleep all the creatures of the natural world, using imagery that quietly compares the forest to a church and its creatures to a hushed, worshipping congregation.

Paraphrasing

Stanza 1:

*Nature, the gentlest mother,
Impatient of no child,
The feeblest or the waywardest, —
Her admonition mild*

Paraphrasing:

The poet describes Nature as the gentlest of mothers, one who is never impatient with any of her children, however weak or however disobedient they may be. Whatever correction she gives is always gentle rather than harsh.

Stanza 2:

*In forest and the hill
By traveller is heard,
Restraining rampant squirrel
Or too impetuous bird.*

Paraphrasing:

Any traveller passing through the forests and hills can hear Nature's gentle, guiding presence at work, calming an overly excited squirrel or reining in an overly impulsive bird.

Stanza 3:

*How fair her conversation,
A summer afternoon, —
Her household, her assembly;
And when the sun goes down*

Paraphrasing:

Nature's "conversation" – the pleasant sounds and presence of her creatures – is lovely on a summer afternoon, when all her creatures gather together like a household or a congregation, and this continues even as the sun begins to set.

Stanza 4:

*Her voice among the aisles
Incites the timid prayer
Of the minutest cricket,
The most unworthy flower.*

Paraphrasing:

As evening falls, Nature's voice moves among the "aisles" of the forest – as though it were a church – encouraging even the smallest cricket and the humblest flower to offer their own quiet, timid "prayer," as if Nature were leading her creatures in evening worship.

Stanza 5:

*When all the children sleep
She turns as long away
As will suffice to light her lamps;
Then, bending from the sky*

Paraphrasing:

Once all her "children" – the creatures of the natural world – have fallen asleep, Nature turns away just long enough to light her "lamps," meaning the stars, before leaning down from the sky above.

Stanza 6:

*With infinite affection
And infiniter care,
Her golden finger on her lip,
Wills silence everywhere.*

Paraphrasing:

With boundless affection and even greater care, Nature places her "golden finger" – suggesting a beam of moonlight – to her lips in a gesture of hushing, commanding silence to settle gently over the whole world so that her children may rest peacefully.

Rhyming Scheme

Each quatrain follows Dickinson's characteristic loose ABCB rhyme scheme: only the second and fourth lines rhyme (often through her typical slant, or near, rhyme – such as *child / mild* and *heard / bird*), while the first and third lines remain unrhymed. This gentle, irregular rhyme, combined with short, simple lines, gives the poem a soft, lullaby-like rhythm well suited to its tender, maternal subject.

Theme

"Mother Nature" presents the natural world as a vast, gentle family, cared for patiently and tenderly by Nature herself, imagined as an ever-attentive mother. Rather than punishing or dominating her creatures,

she guides them mildly, gathers them like a devoted household, and finally settles them to sleep beneath a sky of stars with boundless affection. The poem reflects Dickinson's characteristic reverence for the natural world, portraying it as quietly sacred – almost church-like – in its order, gentleness, and protective calm.

Figures of Speech

• Extended Personification / Allegory

Nature is personified throughout as a gentle mother who cares for, disciplines, and finally lulls to sleep all the creatures of the natural world.

• Religious Imagery

Words such as “aisles,” “prayer,” and “assembly” compare the forest to a church, with its creatures gathered like a hushed, worshipping congregation.

• Metaphor

The stars are described as Nature's “lamps,” and a beam of moonlight is imagined as her “golden finger” hushing the world to silence.

• Imagery

Vivid sensory imagery – squirrels, birds, crickets, flowers, summer afternoons, starlight – brings the natural world vividly and tenderly to life.

• Symbolism

The “golden finger on her lip” symbolises the quiet, protective peace Nature brings over the sleeping world each night.

• Alliteration

The phrase “with infinite affection / And infiniter care” uses repeated sounds and an invented comparative (“infiniter”) to intensify the depth of Nature's tenderness.

• Slant (Near) Rhyme

Dickinson's characteristic use of imperfect rhymes (such as *prayer* / *flower* and *away* / *sky*) gives the poem its distinctive, understated musicality.

Questions & Answers

Q1. How is Nature personified in the poem?

Nature is personified as “the gentlest mother,” who is patient and caring toward all her “children” (creatures), regardless of how weak or disobedient they may be.

Q2. What does Nature do when a squirrel or bird misbehaves?

She gently restrains an overly energetic squirrel or an overly impulsive bird, guiding them with her calm, mild presence rather than harsh correction.

Q3. What imagery compares the forest to a church in stanzas three and four?

Words like “aisles,” “prayer,” and “assembly” compare the forest to a church, with its creatures gathered like a congregation offering quiet, timid prayer.

Q4. What are Nature's “lamps” in the fifth stanza?

They represent the stars, which Nature lights once all her children (the creatures of the natural world) have fallen asleep.

Q5. What gesture does Nature make in the final stanza, and what does it represent?

She places her “golden finger” (suggesting moonlight) on her lips, a hushing gesture that brings gentle silence and peace over the whole sleeping world.

Q6. What is the central theme of the poem?

The poem presents Nature as a gentle, patient, endlessly caring mother figure who nurtures, guides, and protects all her creatures with quiet, almost sacred tenderness.

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